resistance] and Eddington's remark as reported in your letter is utterly obscure. So I think you had better cheer up and not let you scare [*sic*] so much by high priests." In a follow-up letter on the same day, Rosenfeld wrote, "Bohr and I are absolutely unable to see any meaning in Eddington's statements."

But for astronomers, the matter was not so clear at first. They had no expertise in these issues of quantum mechanics and relativity, so Eddington's authority held sway amongst them for several years. Moreover, Eddington stuck to his guns. He was so blinded by his opposition to black holes that his judgment was totally clouded. He so deeply wanted there to "be a law of Nature to prevent a star from behaving in this absurd way" that he continued to believe for the rest of his life that there *is* such a law—when, in fact, there is none.

By the late 1930s, astronomers, having talked to their physicist colleagues, understood Eddington's error, but their respect for his enormous earlier achievements prevented them from saying so in public. In a lecture at an astronomy conference in Paris in 1939, Eddington once again attacked Chandrasekhar's conclusions. As Eddington attacked, Chandrasekhar passed a note to Henry Norris Russell (a famous astronomer from Princeton University in America), who was presiding. Chandrasekhar's note asked for permission to reply. Russell passed back a note of his own saying, "I prefer you don't," even though earlier in the day Russell had told Chandrasekhar privately, "Out there we don't believe in Eddington."

With the world's leading astronomers having finally—at least behind Eddington's back—accepted Chandrasekhar's maximum mass for white dwarfs, were they then ready to admit that black holes might exist in the real Universe? Not at all. If nature provided no law against them of the sort that Eddington had sought, then nature would surely find another way out: Presumably, every massive star would eject enough matter into interstellar space, as it ages or during its death throes, to reduce its mass below 1.4 Suns and thereby enter a safe, white-dwarf grave. This was the view to which most astronomers turned when Eddington lost his battle, and they adhered to it through the 1940s and 1950s, and into the early 1960s.

As for Chandrasekhar, he was badly burned by the controversy with Eddington. As he recalled some forty years later, "I felt that astronomers